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Richard Findley concludes his problem-solving series with a look at the difficulties surrounding faceplate work

Faceplate turning

RICHARD FINDLEY

Richard is a registered UK professional woodturner living and working in Leicestershire. He discovered woodturning while working for his father as a joiner. He makes all kinds of work to commission, from replacement antique components, walking canes and stair spindles, to decorative bowls. It is the variety of work that he loves. He also offers demonstrations and a range of woodturning supplies.

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So, what is faceplate work? Essentially faceplate work covers any type of turning where the grain of the timber is running across the bed of the lathe – as opposed to along the bed of the lathe as in spindle work. Technically bowl turning is faceplate work, but as this has been covered a number of times by myself and other turners, I thought I'd look beyond bowl turning, at some of the other things that can be made in this fashion, and the problems associated with it.

My feeling is that faceplate work is seen as a poor relation to bowl work, and even spindle turning, and is perhaps somewhat overlooked. There is, believe it or not, much more to woodturning than making bowls. Some of the things that fall under the heading of 'faceplate work' include:

- Bases for lamps and candlesticks
- Plinths
- Table tops
- Stool seats
- Coasters
- Chopping boards
- Rosettes

The main problems with this kind of work are mostly associated with understanding the grain direction and how to work with it to achieve the desired results. Without this understanding the results are usually torn grain, catches, poor shapes and poor finish.

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